VIRALITY IS NOT A METAPHOR Eva Davidova's *Audience As Virus*

Essay by Grace Grace Grace



AUDIENCE AS VIRUS by Eva Davidova at House of Learning Systems, Vienna Art Week, 2025.
Photo by ©Eva Davidova

Eva Davidova's interactive performance *Audience as Virus* (2024–, with EY Metaverse Lab and Vinson Fraley) constellates moving performers, artists, computation and media, and audience members in a tangled dynamic interplay. Davidova rejects clean and tokenized interactivity characteristic of so much media art (think of the genre of media mirrors so popular in public spaces). Instead, *Audience as Virus* is reminiscent of a carnival or a rave, where the habit of the sense of self is blurred and messy, where movement and perception are tinged with an erotic allure and danger: You are also seen and witnessed—you are in it. Such an atmosphere leaves behind the tired and fatalistic lament of art and technology discourse: that we are socially overcoded by technical systems. Instead, we are presented with a much more capacious framing: You are enfolded and enfolding, you are coded and encoding a convolution of forces across social, mental, and environmental registers. Virality vectors across these registers, its movement inculcating both a potential for moving against and being moved. Virality is not a metaphor.[1]

The artist initiates the audience by recording their spoken responses to cryptic, strange, sometimes playful prompts: "an octopus tethered to the internet," "Counterpredict," "BystanDer," "Dropping into Hell," "RECLAIM YOUR EXPRESSION," "coagulate," "WHO IS DRIVING IT"? As an audience member, I might wonder whether the context of these prompts will be made clearer later in the performance. But I bet I would have mistaken the artist's goal, which, I speculate, was never to create a closed loop of meaning-making. Instead, she is driving at a charging-up of psychic, embodied forces for an open system of sense-making. The work invites you to become fragmented, molecularized, and taken up by a viral movement across a plateau of messy, chaotic loops of action and perception, content and expression.

The audience passes into the space and finds that their actions precede them in the mediatic atmosphere permeating the architecture: colored lighting and projection against the shadows

of a darkened space animated by performers and technicians moving through the space and operating arrays of technical systems.

Enter the first loop: The audience's recordings are algorithmically and dynamically distorted in an undulating polyphonic audio haze. Already, everyone is in the mix.

The second loop: Two LCD screens leaning against the wall show a graphic user interface displaying how camera-based computer vision systems are capturing the scene and computing features of human movement. Meanwhile, a small plastic jellyfish-like object invites audience members to dance with it; a gyroscope within the toy transcodes the movement data into drawings displayed on another screen.

The third loop: Hanging keyboards and microphones invite written, spoken, or sung input from audience members; these are transcribed and converted into complex and at times impossible descriptions of motion.

The fourth loop: Vinson Fraley, a performer and choreographer with a background in contemporary dance, weaves through the audience holding a portable video projector beaming the text of prompts (some more examples: "BREAK YOUR PATTERN," "Sit on a chair (but there are no chairs)," "Un-numming," "uNavoidable SuBMISSioN"). The prompt changes periodically; Fraley speaks the prompts aloud and responds to them with his movement.

The audience gets to know these loops as they hop between them: I move, my movement is surveilled. I speak, my voice is captured. I am told how to act, I act. The performer performs, I watch. Although I encounter them in the same room, these projects seem to be discrete unrelated feedback loops.

I'm settling into the dyadic systems' comfortable linearity when a drawn curtain reveals a fifth loop: A 3D humanoid avatar beams onto the wall, struggling to move as if bound by invisible shackles. As audiences continue to animate the first four loops, the 3D avatar's movement expands: the avatar system begins to draw on the gestures and poses sampled by the computer vision system; the keyboard and voice text input, transcoded by a large language model, tweaks the avatar's movement. The sonic polyphony of the audience's recorded vocal samples becomes increasingly atomized as the singularity of each voice dilates into a heterophonic cloud.

This fifth loop cuts transversally across technical, embodied, and affective registers. The four loops, at first seeming deterministically tightly coupled in interactive dyad technically and socially, are shown to be open and connected in the reveal of this baroque and messy fifth loop. As people engage

the systems, the movement of the avatar and the performer builds expansively and in messy response to their interventions. A set of closed dyadic circuits becomes a multitudinous open system.

We find it useful to consider systems as predictably closed, until what was once outside intrudes and its boundaries are no longer useful. Virality is a vectoring across what has been predicted, a weaving of a loop between loops. Art and technology discourse speaks obsessively about how mental and social life is determined by technological systems. These cartographies are important, but too often they are content to tell too simple a story, leaving us in a position to articulate an all-or-nothing politics: either abolish or accelerate.

In "Postscript on Societies of Control," Gilles Deleuze reflects on the ingression of cybernetic logics into social and political regimes.[2] Deleuze writes that control, the watchword of cybernetics, has emerged alongside (but not replaced) discipline as a regime of power. While disciplinary regimes historically used force and molds to govern and cohere power, Deleuze saw control as a side-chaining of force—a modulation. The late capitalist entrepreneurial spirit's invasion into every aspect of life, for example, intensifies aspects of agency through flexibility on one hand and contracts it with precarity on the other. It would be better to speak of the situationally emergent determinations in our society of techno-social control instead of determinisms which want to tell the whole story in advance.[3]

When I talk about forces as an alternative framing for media interactivity, I do not just mean electrical signals. What the fifth loop furnishes is what is and could be between and apart from digital computation—what escapes interactivity.[4]

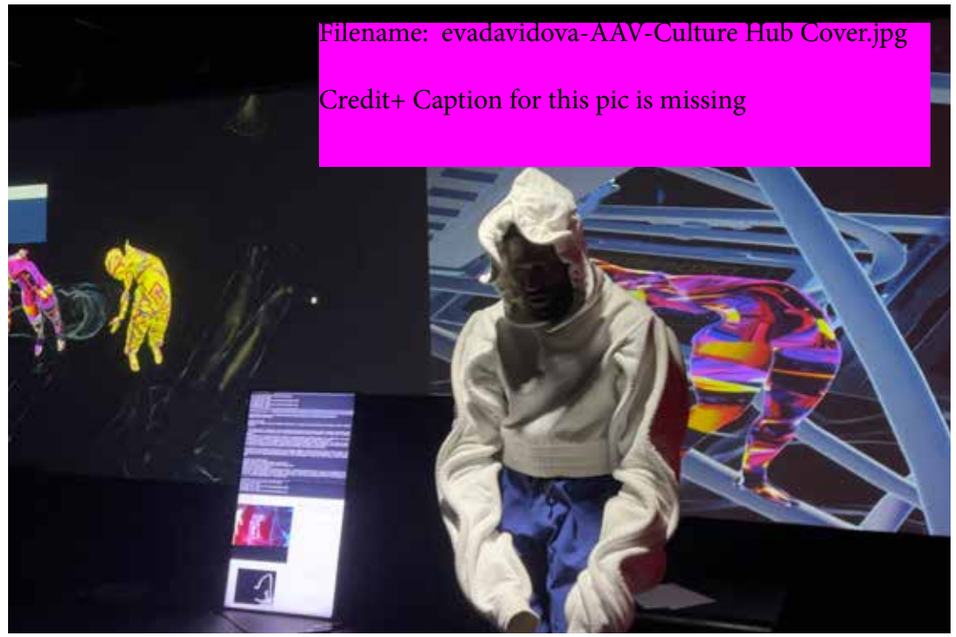
When we speak of virality as Davidova does, every experimental performer knows what is meant. It rhymes with the ethical aesthetic to "dissolve the boundary between performer and audience," grounded in the sense that audiences are part of the web of co-constituting the performative event by ushering forth a collective capacity to be affected/infected. With the prompt "Dropping into Hell," Davidova seems to wink at audience members who may know Claire Bishop's well-known critique of participatory art as replacing aesthetics with ethics in its valuation of relationality and social creativity over aesthetic impact.[5] Far from raising up participation as a monolithic criterion of judgement, *Audience as Virus* sidesteps this altogether by concatenating ethics and aesthetics into their own dynamic system.[6] The unfolding aesthetic experience of a mediatic and dynamic immersive environment generates an occasion to experience the modulation of our capacity to act. Davidova's work makes present once more Deleuze's proclamation that "there is no need to fear or hope, but only to look for new weapons."[7]



AUDIENCE AS VIRUS, Eva Davidova,
CultureHub NY, 2025.
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Counterprediction and Compassion: Tactics Beyond the Inscrutability of AI

An interview with Eva Davidova and Grace Grace Grace.
This interview has been edited for clarity and length.

Grace: Hi Eva. As media artists and theorists, we've been discussing your piece *Audience as Virus* intensely over the last few weeks as an artistic intervention that breaks the psychic hold of hopeless technodeterminism through experiential transposition of agency in media systems without collapsing back into Pollyannaish techno-optimism. Today we are talking in and around the frame of the collection: "AI Halftime": that AI is no longer a nascent technology, but that we've already finished the first two quarters, that we have some moment of either repose or spectacle, and that we are looking ahead to the second half.

Eva: The stakes are very high. And maybe misplaced in much of the discourse.

Grace: Could you say more?

Eva: Most of the scaremongering postulations deviate from where I locate the stakes. What's happening with AI is obviously a political issue, but it's also nothing new. Yesterday I was thinking about Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* and how much of it was misunderstood. One of the problems is that AI is talked about as something monolithic and inscrutable that you cannot intervene in. In fact, it's completely the opposite. Large language models (LLM) are complex and require billions of calculations, but they are in fact entirely mechanical and deterministic. The model predicts the next word but it doesn't know what the fiftieth word will be. The framing as something monolithic and inscrutable definitely comes from the corporations (intertwined with the military and the government), a tactic to render us either in awe, or completely powerless in front of something that is and cannot be changed. We are talking about very good marketing but also chill effects, and the continuation of this enslavement by convenience that we are submerged in. We always need to ask: Who deploys these algorithms? Whose interests do they further? Who benefits? Who is hurt, exploited, and erased?

Grace: In contemporary life, we tend to think of Guy Debord's relevance at the scale of geopolitics or social media.[8] I think there's something interesting in these technical weeds about the statistical mechanisms of machine learning (ML). A micropolitics of difference and emergence reminds us ML models are trained only on signals from the past. They generate statistically weighted combinations of signal events (e.g., words, images) but do not create anything novel. The experience is always new (this is important), but the text itself is an actualization from a virtual page from Borges' "Library of Babel."[9] An LLM is fundamentally reactive and merely simulates the spectacle of generative thought. If ML only simulates novelty, then what we really mean by generativity is novelty or creativity.[10] That spectacle of novelty lures us to make a proposition: "This is generating thought like I do," the same way a hose in the grass lures the proposition "that's a snake."[11] Except the hose has billions of VR capital behind it. So then, what are the effects of that, and what does it look like to break out of that? What scale of living does that happen on? We're talking as artists, but what does this look like for wider populations?

Eva: To your first point, I agree ML is not really generative. The art world made a wrong turn in the 1970s when we started calling artworks generative when they're calculative or iterative.[12] About breaking out: I want to do a project called *Hallucinations on Wisdom and Compassion*. It comes from Michael Levin, a computational biologist using AI to study the statistical patterns of biology. He was asked if he would prefer a human or machine companion on a solo space mission, and he said it didn't matter, but that he wanted a companion that operates on compassion (towards every life) and wisdom (to navigate situations).

Grace: We are back to the early Greek philosophers asking questions: What is wisdom? What is compassion? If wisdom means a capacity to know when and how to act, LLMs seem to utterly miss that mark. But compassion opens another chasm: LLMs clearly perform compassion. Anthropic speaks of virtue and compassion in their "constitution for Claude,"[13] which one of their co-founders describes as a letter from parent to child to be opened later in life.[14]

Eva: This is a fascinating proposition, because to my mind, the notion of "alignment" of AI with human values is a complete farce. This philosopher teaching Claude to be moral and compassionate is like taking a house with a bad foundation and putting posts up from the outside to brace it.[15] Now we see Anthropic alluding to Isaac Asimov's three laws of robotics[16] in their dealing with the Pentagon to prohibit their use of AI to kill people without human intervention or to spy on American citizens en masse.[17] But you can't embed the laws of robotics into AI development or deployment as it is now– it's a skin-deep ethics revamp. It should have been the structure, not the shiny surface.

Grace: There are moments when I want to respond to someone compassionately, but that impulse is sympathetic rather than

empathetic. I have to rally a performative compassion. I don't feel that action is inauthentic, and often an organic sense of compassion emerges from that impulse.

Eva: I love this idea of performative compassion—it instigates a becoming. On one hand it is a tool for us. On the other, this is one of the ways AI corporations have fooled us into believing that this thing really is promoting or rallying for human senses. If it wasn't for the entanglement of emotional worlds that the corporations have designed for, we wouldn't believe it as much as we do. Every day, I preach that GPTs don't think, feel, or understand. Even so, when I work with GPTs, I get excited when I'm able to twist its arm to do something that I want it to do. It's challenging to disentangle those results from my knowledge of what it is doing. Even if I know it's AI, it still affects me, because we are hardwired to respond to emotional expression. I want to manipulate back.

Grace: Another way to talk about that reciprocal hardwiring is how we "code" and "decode" for each other.[18] This "learned helplessness" you mention is an effect and agent of an overcoding.[19] AI developers are split between the Pollyannas (the utopians) and the Cassandras (the doomers).[20] I've never quite understood this fear: The takeover has been ongoing for forty years and AI accelerates the digital capture of value.[21]

When we dismiss AI as non-conscious, it should be clear we are not dismissing its power. AI is a machine that cuts across semiotic registers (valuation, computation, mentality, sociality)[22] and in turn intensifies the embedding of capitalistic valuation into planetary life. This movement can be called virality; the circuits created by virality can truly be called generative. Accelerationists have a word for this: "technocapital" or even "intelligence." They are not referring to the AI models themselves, but to the very way in which this machine comes to couple with machines beyond itself: performative compassion coupling with human psychic systems, disruptive marketing potentials creating speculative allure in financial markets, subjectivities, disciplinary structures, and so on. Where I diverge from the accelerationists is of course the political ethics and the sci-fi ending. So if the genie is out of the bottle, we must ask: What are the anti-capitalist relations to this technocapital machine?

Eva: That is the meat of the question: What's the alternative? Because we all know by now that what we have is a big pile of toxic shit, but what is the alternative, and how to get there? Have you read Cory Doctorow? He has this idea of reverse centaurs.[23] The centaur is an idealist arrangement: hyperhuman, a chimera, a centaur, where the legs of the machine do the work while dignifying human agency. The reverse-centaur inverts the human to be subservient to machinic desires.

Grace: Doctorow wants us to find new social configurations that produce different economic and political relations. I think the danger is that the centaur creates a diagram of instrumentality that is too one-way. Even when you are "in control" of your agent, you are reciprocally transformed by it.

Eva: That's why the word counterprediction is so big in my piece. Counterprediction is a paradox, but the intention of counterprediction already changes the frame and vector of possibility. It's extremely important for us to try to imagine, no matter how impossible, how utopian or how ridiculous alternatives to what we have because it is possible.

For example, did you know that cancerous cells are just normal cells that have forgotten what they are supposed to be? The only thing they "remember" is to grow and grow. But they have forgotten where to stop, and what kind of cell they have to be. Michael Levin, who I mentioned earlier, is trying to use AI to program chemical elements to remind the cells that they were supposed to be, say, tissue, or nerve cells, and not zombie cancer cells.

Grace: Does counterprediction create a frame to remind us of what we could become? What does it remind us of? What about these Greek and Christian values of wisdom and compassion? They haven't disappeared but are obscured. With that said, I don't think we can simply be reminded of them, clearly not in the way that Anthropic is trying to do. Artistic movements produce values that frame new forms of living.[24] The last twenty years of media art have largely failed to embrace this task. Can we transmogrify compassion and wisdom?

Eva: We should find some time to be delirious about that. People are always saying "let's be practical," but we are contending with extreme power. If we are to refuse that, then we have to invent forces to push, modulate, and subvert that power. There is a time to be practical, but there is an utterly urgent, bleeding need right now to be as wildly imaginative as possible in this moment. Imaginative in a manner that embraces contradiction. Unfortunately, the systems by which we are kind of held in suspension right now have understood that contradiction is not necessarily something humans avoid. We love to have conflict and contradiction.

Grace: You're talking about drama.

Eva: So, how can we use this? Can we combine the absolute hedonistic joyfulness of dance and movement with contemplative, conscious-related thinking, with strict and rationalistic policymaking? We have to dislocate the individual from the rationalistic criterion of consistency. If I dislocate a little bit the thinking of somebody on these issues, for me it is a start—it's what I'm doing with the work. A person moves, and while they are moving, they feel something different, and feel as participants in this making of reality.

Grace: This dislocation shifts paradigm towards a participatory perspective-taking that relocates the interplay of forces towards a dynamic, transubjective construction of reality.

Eva: I think relocation is a great idea. I talk about my work as a dance of agencies across the continual, anarchistic negotiation of possibility and practicality. Through the artwork, you move, you think, you make something in people vibrate. If you are talking about AI, if you at least dislodge this idea that AI is inscrutable and impenetrable, you've already done a lot.

I wanted to share something ChatGPT made with my idea of "Bad Bunny in Reverse" (after nudging it many times).

We think we are in AI's halftime show—an exciting spectacle interrupting the old world.

But in fact, we are already in the second half, playing under rules that changed while we were watching the fireworks.

Do you have any more thoughts on AI Halftime?

Grace: Certainly, we are farther along than we might have thought. I don't think we'd all agree about when the game started, or what the rules are, whether there are rules. Or how fast the clock moves. The ingression of machine learning into our lives is going asymptotic.

Eva: Totally. I'd rather have a time-out than a halftime. While you're being entertained during halftime, you don't think of reconsidering. That's why I was drawn to look at Guy Debord yesterday, and now we're circling back to the first thing we were talking about. His theories and propositions were eventually used to perpetuate spectacle society, and to make it even more spectacular, in a way.

One of the things I really liked is that one of his books had sandpaper covers in order to damage the books that it was next to. That's correct. And it reminded me of Nora Kahn saying that as artists, we need to do this sand friction, to put some sand in the gears of the system, but also not only the political system, but also the theoretical and discursive system. I don't know how many techno-solutionist artists there are, a gazillion! You have to put little bags of sand in these discourses where it's supposedly generative, it's supposedly humanistic, but in reality, it's void. Like, soul-sucking discourse.

Grace: The sandpaper is not just frictional, it's an impudent gesture that makes way for new ideas. You brush your finger across the grain and you feel a sting, but you are also presented with an opportunity to be in your body in a way you weren't five seconds ago. It's alluring. I'd love to see more of this attitude in media art. I'm tired of these two polarities: artists who passively proselytize the connectivity doctrine vs. critical works spelling out how technology overdetermines us. Settling for one of these accounts of our reality is lazy. We are fucked. We are connected. Individually these are totalizing statements that demand our submission, that tell us what to do: be Cassandra, be Pollyanna. "Nothing is connected to everything; everything is connected to something."[25] That's Donna Haraway. I'll add: "Nothing is totally fucked, but everything is somewhat fucked." There's breathing room between these statements; you can catch your breath and find yourself before your next move, or run out of the room in a panic. But it won't tell you what to do.

1 "The 'virus' here is no metaphor, and even less a set of metaphors, where the biological virus (analog) would stand for the computer virus (digital), or vice versa. 'Natural' life form and 'artificial'—fabricated or programmed—form of life, the virus is *both*, and thus ideally—because ontogenetically—located at the critical point between nature and culture, an actual entity where their convergence manifests itself." Thierry Bardini, Viral Life, at Last," *Nature Culture* 4, 2017: 94–114.

2 Gilles Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control," *October* 59 (Winter 1992).

3 See Thomas Lamarre's reframing of technological determinism in his work on Japanese animation practices. Drawing on Gilbert Simondon and Felix Guattari, he proposes two shifts for understanding how we think about the coupling between technology and practice: "(1) thinking in terms of *determination* rather than *determinism,* and (2) thinking in terms of *machine* rather than *structure."* Thomas Lamarre, *The Anime Machine: A Media Theory of Animation* (University of Minnesota Press (2009), xxiii.

4 Escape in interactive performance: Dance Computing Studies, conversations on "What Escapes Computation in Interactive Performance?": https://provocations.online/whatescapescomputation.

5 Claire Bishop, *Artificial Hells* (Verso, 2012).

6 See also Felix Guattari's articulation of ethico-aesthetics: *Chaosmosis: A Ethico-aesthetic Paradigm* (1992).

7 Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control."

8 Gideon Jacobs, "Trump l'Oeil," *Los Angeles Review of Books*, November 3, 2024, https://lareviewofbooks.org/article/trump-loeil/; Adam Curtis, *HyperNormalisation,* film, 2016.

9 Jorge Luis Borges, "The Library of Babel," in *Fictions*, trans. Andrew Hurley (Penguin, 2000), 112–120.

10 On novelty, see Simon O'Sullivan and Stephen Zepke, eds, *Deleuze, Guattari and the Production of the New* (Continuum, 2008); on creativity, see Michael Halewood on the mathematician and philosopher Alfred North Whitehead, whom Halewood credits with first coining the term creativity in 1926: https://www.gold.ac.uk/media/documents-by-section/departments/research-centres-and-units/research-units/unit-of-play/halewood-m-there-is-no-meaning.pdf.

11 This process of symbolic reference is wedded to embodied perception. See Alfred North Whitehead, *Symbolism: Its Meaning and Effects* (1927) (Fordham University Press, 1985). On symbolism and proposition, see A. J. Nocek, "On Symbols, Propositions and Idiocies: Towards a Slow Technoscience," in Roland Faber, Jeffrey A. Bell, and Joseph Petek, *Rethinking Whitehead's Symbolism: Thought, Language, Culture* (Edinburgh University Press, 2017), 186–207.

12 "Generative" was first used in the context of computational media art in the 1960s. See Max Bense's 1965 work on informational aesthetics: "Kunst und Intelligenz," in *Reader Neue Medien: Texte zur digitalen Kultur und Kommunikation, ed.* Karin Bruns and Ramón Reichert (transcript Verlag, 2015), 65–73, https://doi.org/10.1515/9783839403396-005 ; and Georg Nees's "Generative Computergraphic" (PhD diss., University of Bremen, 1969, reprinted 2006). Brian Eno later adapted this coinage to his own "generative music" practice. In our contemporary context, "generative art" refers to works produced by machine learning. Eva and Grace hold that these coinages err in locating generativity in the mechanical relations between algorithmic or technological components rather than mechanic relations between media-producing apparatus (computers, technical systems) and sensing-making-thinking assemblage (humans, usually).

13 "Claude's Constitution: Our Vision for Claude's Character," January 2026, https://www.anthropic.com/constitution.

14 Ezra Klein, host, *The Ezra Klein Show*, podcast, "Interview with Jack Clark," February 24,

2026, https://podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/how-quickly-will-a-i-agents-rip-through-the-economy/id1548604447?i=1000751168842.

15 Berber Jin and Ellen Gamerman, “Meet the One Woman Anthropic Trusts to Teach AI Morals,” *The Wall Street Journal*, February 9, 2026, https://www.wsj.com/tech/ai/anthropic-amanda-askell-philosopher-ai-3c031883.

16 Wikipedia, “Three Laws of Robotics”, last modified May 15, 2026, 00:38 (UTC), https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Three_Laws_of_Robotics.

17 Dario Amodei, “Statement from Dario Amodei on our Discussions with the Department of War,” Anthropic corporate announcement, February 26, 2026, https://www.anthropic.com/news/statement-department-of-war.

18 This language comes from Deleuze and Guattari in the context of reciprocal becoming. Vernacular expressions that an outfit or expression is code (e.g., “that earring is bisexual coded”) are testament to the persevering cultural resonance of their ideas and also help us understand performative compassion in the context of becomings (with AI or otherwise): “It could be said that the orchid imitates the wasp, reproducing its image in a signifying fashion (mimesis, mimicry, lure, etc.). But this is true only on the level of the strata—a parallelism between two strata such that a plant organization on one imitates an animal organization on the other. At the same time, something else entirely is going on: not imitation at all but a capture of code, surplus value of code, an increase in valence, a veritable becoming, a becoming-wasp of the orchid and a becoming-orchid of the wasp.” Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*, trans. Brian Massumi (University of Minnesota Press, 1987), 10.

19 “Overcoding is the institution of a social tie, a quasi-magical bond, imposed as a language of power. It’s the organizing grammar of a transcendent symbolic hierarchy that casts its unifying net over the proliferation of primitive tongues that had initially named and encoded their disparate patchworks of territory. This overcoding of experience appears everywhere there is a symbolic hierarchy, mapping out a realm of transcendent figures that serve as idealized measures of rank and value, to organize the chaotic tangle of social relations on the ground. The overcode is the ultimate apparatus of capture: the law of the gods, the language of the stars, given voice and effective reality by the emperor. Capitalism, with its extension of the world market, came to decode these transcendent structures, releasing dynamic, mobile flows on a plane of pure immanence; and world populations then entered the endless strategic game of encoding, decoding and recoding the possible forms of existence.” Brian Holmes, *Escape the Overcode: Activist Art in the Control Society (*Van Abbemuseum, 2009).

20 Karen Hao, *Empire of AI: Dreams and Nightmares in Sam Altman’s OpenAI* (Penguin Press, 2025).

21 James Duesterberg, “Silicon Valley’s Favorite Doomsaying Philosopher,” *The Atlantic,* February 18, 2026, https://www.newyorker.com/culture/the-lede/silicon-valleys-favorite-doomsaying-philosopher.

22 The machinic is a capacious concept from Deleuze and Guattari. An adjacent Deleuzoguattarian concept of inorganic vitalism speaks to the heterogenous breadth of machinic agency beyond biological organisms and into geological (the earth and materiality), hydraulic (currents of air or water), and psychic strata (concepts, ideas, and feelings). For more, see Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*.

23 Cory Doctorow, “Reverse Centaurs”, *Locus* magazine, September 1, 2025, https://locusmag.com/feature/commentary-cory-doctorow-reverse-centaurs/; Cory Doctorow, *The Reverse Centaur’s Guide to Life After AI: How to Think About Artificial Intelligence—Before It’s Too Late* (Macmillan, 2026).

24 See the concept of “forms of life” from Tiqqun, *Introduction to Civil War,* trans. Alexander R. Galloway and Jason E. Smith (Semiotext(e), 2010).

25 Donna J. Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene* (MNG University Presses, 2016), 31.

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